▼ GLASSHOUSE



LOYALTY POINTS

Rahul Gandhi is done being evasive about who runs the Congress. A run of appointments has quietly rewarded the men who stood by him. Data man **Praveen Chakravarty** was elected to the Rajya Sabha from Tamil Nadu on a seat the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) handed the party. **Manickam Tagore**, the anti-DMK firebrand, now heads the state unit. **Meenakshi Natarajan** was pushed for a Madhya Pradesh Rajya Sabha berth (her nomination was rejected). But the rewards have made the old guard restive. In Punjab, **Amarinder Singh Raja Warring** was retained as state chief, triggering an open revolt by ex-CM Charanjit Singh Channi's camp. In Madhya Pradesh, 79-year-old **Digvijaya Singh** publicly contradicted his own state chief **Jitu Patwari's** Rs 500-crore land scam charge against CM Mohan Yadav of the BJP. In Rajasthan, ex-CM **Ashok Gehlot** has resumed his needling of **Sachin Pilot**. Still, Rahul's message seems clear—the young turks who keep the faith will move up. The rest can read the memo.

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▼ SHIFTING PERCEPTION

THE HEX FACTOR

When Nitish Kumar's son and new Bihar health minister **Nishant Kumar** moved into his 5, Deshratna Marg residence in Patna, the shifting vans carried more than furniture. They also revived one of Bihar's favourite political superstitions. The bungalow, it seems, has a reputation: its occupants, especially those who served as deputy CMs, rarely complete their innings on a comforting note. Sushil Kumar Modi, Tarkishore Prasad, Tejashwi Yadav, all of them occupied the address at different points, and each saw his tenure 'interrupted'. Yet the legend has a twist. Former deputy CM Samrat Choudhary left the bungalow to take on the top post. Perhaps, then, the jinx has run its course. Whatever be the case, it's got Patna's busybodies active again, dissecting the likely trajectory of Nishant's innings in the bungalow.

